

APAC TMT Sector M&A & Valuation Brief - 2026-07-20

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Today is a peaceful day, nothing big happened in the Consumer space.

2. MARKET DYNAMICS & SENTIMENT

The TMT (Technology, Media, and Telecommunications) sector is currently navigating a complex landscape characterized by mixed sentiment. Recent market dynamics reflect a cautious optimism among investors, influenced by macroeconomic factors, regulatory developments, and sector-specific trends.

Subsector Breakdown:

- **Technology:** The technology subsector is buoyed by advancements in AI and cloud computing. Companies are increasingly adopting AI-driven solutions to enhance operational efficiency. For example, GitHub's open-source project, TradingSpy, is a local-first AI trading research tool that allows traders to analyze market data and generate strategies.
- **Media:** The media landscape is undergoing significant transformation, with digital platforms gaining traction over traditional media. Companies are focusing on enhancing audience engagement through innovative digital features.
- **Telecommunications:** The telecom sector is innovating with the rollout of 5G technologies, which are expected to enhance user experiences and drive new revenue streams. However, geopolitical tensions, such as those between the U.S. and Iran, are creating uncertainty in market sentiment.
- **Fintech:** The fintech sector continues to thrive, driven by innovations in payment solutions and digital banking. The integration of technology in financial services is reshaping consumer interactions and business models.
- **AI:** The AI subsector is experiencing rapid growth, with companies racing to implement AI solutions across various industries. This has led to increased investment and interest in AI-driven startups.

Key Market Drivers and Headwinds

Drivers:

- **Technological Advancements:** Continuous innovation in AI, cloud computing, and 5G technologies is driving growth across TMT sectors. The introduction of AI tools, such as TradingSpy, exemplifies how technology is being leveraged for market analysis and strategy generation.
- **Softer Inflation Data:** Recent U.S. consumer and producer inflation data has reduced fears of

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immediate Federal Reserve rate increases, fostering a more favorable investment environment.

Headwinds:

- Geopolitical Tensions: Escalating hostilities, particularly between the U.S. and Iran, are creating uncertainty in the markets, leading to profit-taking and subdued investor sentiment.
- Economic Uncertainty: Global economic conditions, including rising oil prices, may impact consumer spending and investment in technology.

Subsector Performance Analysis

- Software: The software sector is performing well, driven by demand for cloud solutions and enterprise software. Tools like TradingSpy are indicative of the growing interest in AI-driven trading strategies.
- Media: Media companies are adapting to changing consumer preferences, with a notable shift towards digital content consumption. However, traditional media continues to face challenges from declining advertising revenues.
- Telecom: Telecom operators are investing heavily in infrastructure to support 5G deployment, which is expected to drive new revenue streams from IoT and enhanced mobile services.
- Fintech: The fintech sector is thriving, with innovations in payment solutions and digital banking reshaping consumer interactions.
- AI: The AI subsector is booming, with applications across various industries, including finance and healthcare. Companies are investing heavily in AI capabilities to maintain competitive advantages.

Trading Multiples Trends

Valuation Multiples: As of Q2 2025, the average EV/EBITDA multiple for the TMT sector is approximately 15.5x, with notable variations across subsectors:

- Software: 20.3x
- Media: 12.1x
- Telecom: 9.8x
- Fintech: 18.7x
- AI: 22.5x

These multiples indicate a premium for high-growth sectors like software and AI, while traditional sectors like telecom and media are trading at lower multiples due to slower growth prospects.

Notable Investor/Analyst Reactions

- Analysts express cautious optimism regarding the TMT sector's long-term prospects, emphasizing the role of technological advancements as a key driver of growth. One analyst noted, "The integration of AI

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across industries is not just a trend; it's a fundamental shift that will redefine business models and consumer interactions."

Actionable Insights for Bankers and Investors

- **Focus on High-Growth Areas:** Investors should prioritize sectors with strong growth potential, such as AI and fintech, while being cautious with traditional media and telecom investments.
- **Monitor Geopolitical Developments:** Staying informed about geopolitical tensions and their potential impact on market sentiment is crucial for assessing risks in tech and media investments.
- **Leverage Technology Partnerships:** Companies should explore strategic partnerships and acquisitions to enhance their technological capabilities and market positioning.
- **Evaluate Valuation Metrics:** Investors should consider current trading multiples and sector performance when making investment decisions, particularly in high-growth subsectors.

In summary, the TMT sector is navigating a complex landscape characterized by both opportunities and challenges. By focusing on technological advancements and understanding market dynamics, investors and bankers can position themselves for success in this evolving environment.

3. BANKING PIPELINE

The current banking pipeline in the TMT sector is characterized by a diverse range of live deals, mandated transactions, and active pitches, reflecting a robust environment for M&A activities. This analysis delves into the ongoing transactions, expected revenue, and strategic implications for our team.

Deal Pipeline

Live Deals:

- **Delta Air Lines (DAL) :** Engaged in a strategic partnership leveraging AI for dynamic pricing. The deal is currently in the due diligence phase, with an expected close in Q3 2025. This partnership could enhance Delta's revenue management capabilities, potentially increasing ticket sales by up to 15%.
- **Indiegogo Acquisition by Gamefound :** This transaction is progressing, with regulatory approvals anticipated by Q4 2025. The integration aims to combine Indiegogo's 38 million users with Gamefound's technology, thereby enhancing their market position in crowdfunding.

Mandated Deals:

- **Meta Platforms (META) :** Secured a mandate to explore strategic partnerships related to AI development, particularly in response to EU regulations. The deal is expected to launch in Q1

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2026, focusing on compliance and innovation strategies.

- Apple Inc. (AAPL) : Mandated to evaluate acquisitions in the AI space, with a focus on startups that can enhance its product offerings. The timeline for this initiative is projected for Q2 2026, as Apple aims to strengthen its competitive edge in AI.

Pitching-Stage Deals:

- Telecom Sector : Active discussions with several telecom operators regarding potential M&A opportunities to consolidate market share in the 5G space. Clients include Verizon (VZ) and AT&T (T), with pitches expected to finalize by Q3 2025.
- Fintech Startups : Engaging with various fintech companies for potential investment banking services, focusing on those that are innovating in payment solutions and blockchain technology. Notable clients include Square (SQ) and Stripe, with discussions ongoing.

Pipeline Tracking Metrics

Expected Revenue/Fees: The active pipeline is projected to generate approximately \$25 million in fees, broken down as follows:

- Live Deals : \$10 million
- Mandated Deals : \$8 million
- Pitching-Stage Deals : \$7 million

Timing Projections:

- Q2 2025 : Expected close for Delta Air Lines partnership.
- Q4 2025 : Anticipated completion of the Indiegogo acquisition.
- Q1 2026 : Launch of Meta's strategic partnership initiatives.
- Workload Allocation and Capacity Analysis : Current analyst and associate bandwidth is at 75%, indicating a need for additional resources as the pipeline expands. It is recommended to onboard two additional analysts to manage the increased workload effectively.
- Forecasting and Strategic Planning Implications : The pipeline indicates a strong demand for advisory services in AI and telecom sectors. Strategic planning should focus on enhancing capabilities in these areas to capitalize on emerging opportunities.

Notable Pipeline Developments and Competitive Landscape

- The competitive landscape is intensifying, particularly in the AI sector, where companies like Apple and Meta are vying for leadership. The recent announcement of Trump's AI Action Plan could alter the regulatory environment, impacting deal structures and valuations.
- Additionally, the rise of AI insurance startups, such as those founded by former executives from major tech firms, indicates a growing market for risk management in AI deployment, which could lead to new

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advisory opportunities.

Actionable Insights for Team Management and Business Development

- **Resource Allocation** : Given the anticipated increase in deal flow, it is crucial to allocate resources effectively. Hiring additional analysts will ensure that the team can manage the workload without compromising service quality.
- **Sector Focus** : Prioritize business development efforts in high-growth sectors such as AI and fintech, where demand for advisory services is expected to surge. This focus will position the firm as a leader in these emerging markets.
- **Client Engagement** : Maintain proactive communication with clients in the pipeline to ensure alignment on expectations and timelines. Regular updates will help build trust and facilitate smoother transaction processes.

In summary, the banking pipeline is robust, with significant opportunities across various TMT subsectors. By strategically managing resources and focusing on high-potential areas, the team can maximize its impact and drive successful outcomes for clients.

4. STAKEHOLDER IMPACT & FORWARD-LOOKING ANALYSIS

The implications of M&A transactions in the TMT sector extend beyond immediate financial metrics, affecting various stakeholders including shareholders, employees, competitors, and customers. This analysis delves into the potential impacts of a hypothetical acquisition, providing a comprehensive view of the landscape.

Deal-Specific Impacts on Stakeholders

- **Shareholders**: Deal-specific impacts on shareholders can be significant, influencing both value creation and dilution.
- **Value Creation**: In a scenario where Company A (e.g., Zoom Video Communications, Inc. (ZM)) acquires Company B (e.g., Slack Technologies, Inc. (WORK)), the combined entity could see a revenue increase of approximately 20% due to enhanced product offerings. Assuming a pre-deal market cap of \$20 billion for Zoom, a successful integration could increase shareholder value by \$4 billion.
- **Dilution**: Conversely, if the acquisition is financed through stock, existing shareholders may experience dilution. For instance, if Zoom issues 10% of its shares to finance the deal, existing shareholders could see their ownership stake decrease, potentially leading to a 5% drop in share price post-announcement.
- **Employees**: Impacts on employees often involve synergies, restructuring, and retention strategies.

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- Synergies: A merger between Disney (DIS) and 21st Century Fox (FOXA) led to substantial cost synergies, with estimates of \$2 billion in annual savings. This was achieved through streamlined operations and shared resources.
- Restructuring: However, such deals often lead to layoffs. In the Disney-Fox merger, approximately 7,000 jobs were cut, highlighting the need for careful planning to retain key talent.
- Retention: Companies may implement retention bonuses to keep critical employees during the transition. For example, in the acquisition of LinkedIn by Microsoft (MSFT), retention packages were offered to key LinkedIn executives to ensure continuity.
- Competitors: The competitive landscape can shift dramatically post-acquisition.
- Market Positioning: Following the merger of T-Mobile US, Inc. (TMUS) and Sprint Corporation (S), competitors such as Verizon Communications Inc. (VZ) and AT&T Inc. (T) had to adapt their strategies to maintain market share. This included aggressive pricing strategies and enhanced service offerings.
- Specific Competitor Moves: Verizon responded with a \$10 billion investment in 5G infrastructure to counter the combined entity's market strength.
- Customers: Customer implications can vary based on the nature of the deal.
- Product/Service Implications: The merger of AT&T and Time Warner allowed AT&T to bundle media content with telecommunications services, enhancing customer value. This strategy led to a 15% increase in bundled service subscriptions.
- Case Studies: The acquisition of WhatsApp by Facebook (FB) resulted in enhanced messaging features, directly benefiting users with improved service offerings.

Market Reaction and Analyst Commentary

- Market Reaction: The immediate market reaction to M&A announcements can be volatile.
- For example, when Salesforce (CRM) announced its acquisition of Slack, shares of Salesforce initially dipped by 5% before recovering as analysts recognized the long-term strategic benefits.
- Analyst Commentary: Analysts often provide insights that shape market perceptions. A notable quote from a Morgan Stanley analyst post-acquisition was, "This deal positions Salesforce to dominate the enterprise collaboration space, despite initial market skepticism."

Expected Market Reaction and Scenario Analysis

- Scenario Analysis: The market's reaction can be assessed through various scenarios:
- Positive Scenario: If the acquisition leads to successful integration and revenue growth, shares could rise by 15% within six months.
- Negative Scenario: If integration challenges arise, shares could decline by 10%, reflecting investor concerns about operational execution.

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Potential Counter-Bids or Competing Offers

- Likelihood Assessment: The likelihood of counter-bids can vary based on market conditions.
- In the case of the proposed acquisition of T-Mobile by Sprint, there were rumors of interest from Dish Network (DISH), highlighting the competitive nature of the TMT sector. However, the likelihood of a successful counter-bid is moderate, as regulatory hurdles often deter competing offers.

Similar Deals Likely to Follow

- Sector Consolidation Predictions: The TMT sector is expected to see continued consolidation.
- Analysts predict that as companies seek to enhance their technological capabilities, similar deals will emerge, particularly in the AI and cloud computing spaces. Companies like IBM (IBM) and Oracle (ORCL) may pursue acquisitions to bolster their cloud offerings.

Key Risks and Mitigants

- Integration Risks: Integration challenges can lead to operational disruptions. Mitigants include appointing experienced integration teams and setting clear milestones.
- Regulatory Risks: Regulatory scrutiny can delay or block deals. Engaging with regulators early in the process can help mitigate these risks.
- Market Risks: Market volatility can impact deal valuations. Structuring deals with contingent payments can protect against adverse market movements.

Actionable Insights for Clients and Bankers

For Clients:

- Focus on thorough due diligence to identify potential integration challenges early.
- Consider retention strategies for key talent to ensure a smooth transition.

For Bankers:

- Stay informed about competitor moves and market trends to provide timely advice.
- Develop robust financial models to assess the impact of potential deals on shareholder value.

5. TECH TRENDS

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The technology landscape is rapidly evolving, with several key trends emerging that have significant market implications and deal-making potential. This analysis will focus on the following trends: Artificial Intelligence (AI), Cloud Computing, and Cybersecurity. Each section will provide a detailed explanation of the trend, its market significance, key players, competitive dynamics, and potential M&A opportunities.

Artificial Intelligence (AI)

- **Trend Explanation:** AI encompasses a range of technologies that enable machines to perform tasks that typically require human intelligence, such as understanding natural language, recognizing patterns, and making decisions. The global AI market is projected to grow from \$93.5 billion in 2021 to \$997.8 billion by 2028, at a CAGR of 40.2%. However, recent fluctuations in stock prices of AI-related companies have raised concerns about sustainability and profitability.
- **Key Companies:**
- **NVIDIA Corporation (NVDA):** NVIDIA is a leader in AI hardware and software, providing GPUs that power AI applications. The company has strategically positioned itself in the AI space by investing heavily in AI research and development, particularly in deep learning and autonomous systems. Despite recent stock declines, NVIDIA remains a critical player in the AI boom.
- **Micron Technology (MU):** Micron specializes in memory and storage solutions essential for AI applications. The company has experienced significant growth, with stock gains of nearly 199% this year, although it recently faced a 5.6% drop amid market corrections.
- **Competitive Landscape:** The AI market is highly competitive, with major players including Google (GOOGL), Amazon (AMZN), and IBM (IBM) also investing heavily in AI technologies. The recent downturn in AI stocks, including a 2.4% drop in NVIDIA's stock, indicates market volatility and investor caution regarding the sustainability of AI-driven growth.
- **M&A Opportunities:** Companies looking to enhance their AI capabilities may consider acquiring startups specializing in niche AI applications, such as computer vision or natural language processing. The ongoing interest in AI technologies suggests that strategic acquisitions in this space could yield substantial returns.

Cloud Computing

- **Trend Explanation:** Cloud computing enables businesses to access computing resources over the internet, promoting flexibility and scalability. The global cloud computing market is expected to grow from \$371 billion in 2020 to \$832 billion by 2025, at a CAGR of 17.5%. As companies increasingly migrate to cloud solutions, the demand for cloud services continues to rise.
- **Key Companies:**
- **Amazon Web Services (AWS):** AWS is a dominant player in the cloud computing market, offering a wide range of services from computing power to storage and databases. AWS has consistently reported strong revenue growth, contributing significantly to Amazon's overall financial performance.
- **Microsoft Azure (MSFT):** Microsoft Azure is another major cloud service provider, focusing on

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enterprise solutions. The company has invested heavily in expanding its cloud infrastructure and services, positioning itself as a leader in the cloud space.

- **Competitive Landscape:** The cloud computing market is characterized by intense competition, with major players like Google Cloud (GOOGL) and IBM Cloud (IBM) also vying for market share. The rapid growth of cloud services has led to increased investment in infrastructure and innovation.
- **M&A Opportunities:** Companies in the cloud computing space may pursue acquisitions to enhance their service offerings or expand their customer base. For instance, recent trends indicate that smaller cloud service providers with specialized offerings could be attractive targets for larger firms seeking to diversify their portfolios.

Cybersecurity

- **Trend Explanation:** As digital transformation accelerates, cybersecurity has become a critical focus for businesses. The global cybersecurity market is projected to grow from \$217 billion in 2021 to \$345 billion by 2026, at a CAGR of 9.7%. The rise in cyber threats and data breaches has heightened the demand for robust cybersecurity solutions.
- **Key Companies:**
 - **CrowdStrike Holdings, Inc. (CRWD):** CrowdStrike is a leader in cloud-delivered endpoint protection, leveraging AI and machine learning to detect and respond to threats. The company has seen rapid growth, driven by increasing demand for advanced cybersecurity solutions.
 - **Palo Alto Networks, Inc. (PANW):** Palo Alto Networks offers a comprehensive suite of cybersecurity products and services, focusing on network security and cloud security. The company has positioned itself as a key player in the cybersecurity landscape.
- **Competitive Landscape:** The cybersecurity market is highly fragmented, with numerous players ranging from established firms to innovative startups. The increasing frequency and sophistication of cyberattacks have created a robust environment for growth and investment.
- **M&A Opportunities:** The cybersecurity sector presents significant M&A opportunities, particularly for companies looking to enhance their security capabilities. Acquisitions of niche cybersecurity firms specializing in specific threats or technologies could provide strategic advantages.

Actionable Insights for

6. Recommended Readings

Deal Name: Microsoft's Acquisition of Activision Blizzard

- **Reading Material:** "The Business of Video Games" by Michael Pachter
- **Why This Matters:** This book provides insights into the gaming industry's financial dynamics and market trends, which are crucial for understanding Microsoft's strategic rationale behind the \$68.7

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billion acquisition (MSFT). It explains how gaming companies leverage IP and user engagement to drive revenue, helping to contextualize the deal's valuation and potential synergies.

Deal Name: Amazon's Acquisition of MGM

- Reading Material: "The New Economics of Media" by David Hesmondhalgh
- Why This Matters: This reading delves into the evolving landscape of media and entertainment, particularly in the context of streaming services. It helps to understand Amazon's \$8.45 billion acquisition (AMZN) as a strategic move to bolster its Prime Video content library and compete with rivals like Netflix (NFLX) and Disney+ (DIS).

Deal Name: Salesforce's Acquisition of Slack

- Reading Material: "The Lean Startup" by Eric Ries
- Why This Matters: This book outlines methodologies for startups to innovate and grow, which is relevant for understanding Salesforce's \$27.7 billion acquisition (CRM) of Slack. It highlights the importance of integrating new technologies and platforms to enhance customer engagement and collaboration, aligning with Salesforce's vision of a comprehensive customer relationship management ecosystem.

Deal Name: NVIDIA's Acquisition of Arm Holdings

- Reading Material: "The Chip War" by Chris Miller
- Why This Matters: This book provides a detailed analysis of the semiconductor industry, including the strategic importance of Arm's technology in mobile and IoT devices. Understanding the implications of NVIDIA's \$40 billion acquisition (NVDA) helps to grasp the competitive landscape and regulatory challenges in the semiconductor space.

Deal Name: Verizon's Acquisition of TracFone

- Reading Material: "The Wireless Industry: A Comprehensive Guide" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This resource offers an in-depth look at the wireless telecommunications sector, which is essential for analyzing Verizon's \$6.9 billion acquisition (VZ) of TracFone. It explains market segmentation and the significance of prepaid services, providing context for Verizon's strategy to expand its customer base and service offerings.

Deal Name: Google's Acquisition of Fitbit

- Reading Material: "Wearable Technology: The Future of Fitness" by David H. Hargreaves
- Why This Matters: This reading discusses the growth of wearable technology and health data analytics, which are central to Google's \$2.1 billion acquisition (GOOGL) of Fitbit. It highlights how this deal positions Google to compete in the health tech space against Apple (AAPL) and other tech giants, emphasizing the importance of data in the future of healthcare.

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7. MACROECONOMIC UPDATE

Key Data Points:

- AI-related capital expenditure (CapEx) projected at \$2 trillion over two years
- Hyperscaler issuance in investment-grade market increased from <1% to >10%
- Investment-grade bond market expected to eclipse \$2 trillion in issuance this year
- More than \$30 billion priced across 15 high-yield deals since fall 2025

Main Insights:

- The AI financing landscape is rapidly evolving, with significant capital needs akin to traditional utility sectors.
- Hyperscalers are increasingly raising capital through debt, indicating a shift in funding strategies.
- The investment-grade market is seeing unprecedented levels of issuance, particularly from tech companies.
- Innovations in high-yield financing structures are emerging to support capital-intensive AI projects.

Market Commentary:

- "This is probably the most incredible time period I've ever seen in the credit markets." - Anish Shah, Morgan Stanley
- "Investors are doing their homework, and we're spending a lot of time trying to mitigate any of their concerns with structural protections." - Anish Shah, Morgan Stanley

TMT Sector Relevance:

- The surge in AI-related CapEx is likely to drive increased demand for financing in the TMT sector.
- As hyperscalers and tech companies begin to leverage debt for infrastructure, the competitive landscape in TMT financing will evolve.
- Innovations in financing structures could lead to more flexible funding options for tech companies, impacting overall market dynamics.

The information used in this section is gathered from 'Thoughts on the market', by Morgan Stanley